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works are not concerned with politics.

The reality is that we cannot do away with politics if we are to solve our overwhelming social issues—poverty and crime, for example. Consider this extract from Jack London's *People of the Abyss*, "The *Abyss* is an economic pit of despair, one into which pours a flood of vigorous strong life that perishes by the third generation. The city is a large maw into which tumble down the exploited millions, who eke out their lives in misery, dumb desperation and filth." He refers to London circa 1900. Similarly, crime and pork barrel politics were rampant in Chicago and New York, not too long ago. Yet, the US and UK are considered amongst the most mature democracies of the world today. This did not happen overnight, nor

did it happen without the continuing investment towards a political ideal by both government and the people.

In India, we have long been used to a relationship of patronage, ruled by feudal lords, maharajas, and the Raj. We have yet to embrace the power of the citizen in a democracy. We are a billion voices with the power of a billion votes at our command. Our right to vote is the privilege of our democracy and a civic duty. Yet, we have reduced our role to that of a complainant and critic of our governments. Most of us do not invest in our political identity or political beliefs. In striking contrast to what we are currently witnessing in the US, average citizens and students in India do not campaign for political candidates, or attend public meetings, or concern

Lending an educated hand:
Children attending a class
by the NGO Pratham at
Kankrola village, Haryana